



INTERMEDIATE COOKING *Techniques*



MASTER
YOUR
SKILLS



ADVANCED
TECHNIQUES



ELEVATE
YOUR
COOKING



CREATE
BOLD
FLAVOR

TAKE YOUR
COOKING
TO THE
NEXT LEVEL

BUILD SKILLS. CREATE FLAVOR.
COOK WITH CONFIDENCE.



TECHNIQUES | METHODS | RECIPES

COOK BETTER. EVERY DAY.

Created by Chef Eliane Muskus

EPICUREAN FLOW COURSE

Intermediate Cooking Techniques

Course created by Chef Eliane Muskus

Techniques | Methods | Recipes

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Course Description

Welcome to Intermediate Cooking Techniques, an online course designed to help you take your culinary skills to the next level. Whether you are an amateur chef looking to expand your repertoire or a seasoned home cook seeking to refine your techniques, this course will provide you with the knowledge and confidence to create delicious and impressive dishes.

First Things First

Before starting your cooking session, there are a few important things you should do to set yourself up for success. Here are some key steps to take as part of your pre-cooking routine:

1. **Read the Recipe Thoroughly:** Read the entire recipe from start to finish. Make sure you understand all the steps, ingredients, and cooking techniques involved. This will help you plan your cooking process and ensure that you have everything you need.
2. **Gather Your Ingredients:** Once you have familiarized yourself with the recipe, gather all the ingredients you will need. Check your pantry and refrigerator against the ingredient list. If something is missing, make a quick trip to the store or find a suitable substitute.

Preparing for Success

3. **Prepare Your Mise en Place:** Measure, chop, and organize all your ingredients before you start cooking. This will make the cooking process smoother and more efficient.
4. **Sharpen Your Knives:** Having sharp knives is essential for safe and efficient cooking. Take a few minutes to sharpen your knives before you begin so chopping and slicing are easier.
5. **Organize Your Workspace:** Clear your countertops and organize your tools and equipment. Keep the pots, pans, utensils, and other tools you need within easy reach.
6. **Clean as You Go:** Begin with a clean, tidy kitchen and have a sink of hot, soapy water ready. Washing as you cook helps you maintain an organized workspace.
7. **Preheat Your Oven or Cooktop:** If the recipe requires a preheated oven or pan, do this before preparing your ingredients. Your cooking surface will then be ready when you need it.

Following these steps establishes a reliable routine, reduces stress, and helps you achieve better results in the kitchen.

Why Mise en Place Matters



Everything ready, measured, and within reach.

Why Mise en Place Matters

Everything in Its Place

Mise en place is a French culinary term that means "everything in its place." It is the practice of gathering and preparing all the ingredients, tools, equipment, and utensils needed for a recipe before you start cooking.

1. **Efficiency:** Having everything ready helps you work more efficiently. You will not waste time searching for ingredients or tools while food is cooking, which helps prevent overcooking, burning, or undercooking.
2. **Accuracy:** Measuring and preparing ingredients in advance ensures that you have the correct amounts. This prevents mistakes and helps the dish turn out as intended.
3. **Organization:** Mise en place keeps you focused and reduces the chance of forgetting an ingredient or step. It also helps you keep the work area clean and tidy.
4. **Time Management:** Preparing ahead allows you to assess the recipe, plan each step, and bring everything together smoothly and on time.
5. **Stress Reduction:** Cooking becomes more enjoyable and less overwhelming when everything you need is at your fingertips.

For home cooks, practicing mise en place develops good kitchen habits, saves time and energy, and creates a calmer cooking experience.

Flavor Profiles and Seasoning



A balanced dish begins with thoughtful preparation and seasoning.

Understanding Flavor Profiles

1. Understanding Flavor Profiles: Flavor profiles refer to the combination of tastes, aromas, and textures that make up a dish. Understanding them helps you create food that is balanced and delicious.
 - Different cuisines have distinctive flavor profiles. Italian cuisine often features tomatoes, garlic, olive oil, basil, and oregano, while Thai cuisine frequently combines sweet, sour, spicy, and salty flavors.
 - Understanding flavor profiles helps you pair ingredients that complement one another and create harmonious combinations.

Balancing the Five Basic Tastes

- Sweetness can come from sugar, fruits, carrots, and beets.
- Saltiness enhances other flavors and may come from salt, soy sauce, or miso.
- Sourness adds brightness and may come from citrus fruit, vinegar, or yogurt.
- Bitterness can come from dark leafy greens, coffee, or chocolate.
- Umami is a savory taste found in tomatoes, mushrooms, soy sauce, and Parmesan cheese.

Balancing sweet, salty, sour, bitter, and umami creates depth and complexity, making a dish more satisfying to eat.

Mastering Seasoning Techniques

3. Mastering Seasoning Techniques: Seasoning is the process of adding salt, pepper, and other flavorings to enhance a dish. Add seasoning gradually and taste along the way so that the flavors remain balanced. Over-seasoning can overpower the other ingredients.

Herbs, spices, citrus zest, and condiments can add depth and complexity. Techniques vary with the dish, so experiment and develop your own sense of taste.

Experimenting with Herbs and Spices

- Herbs are usually the leaves of plants and can be used fresh or dried. Common examples include basil, parsley, thyme, rosemary, and cilantro.
- Spices come from the seeds, bark, roots, or fruit of plants and are often dried and ground. Common examples include cinnamon, cumin, paprika, turmeric, and ginger.
- Consider the flavor profile of the dish and how each herb or spice will complement the other ingredients.
- Start with small amounts, taste as you go, and explore new combinations.

Essential Kitchen Knives



Nakiri knife



Chef's knife



Santoku knife

Knife Selection and Safety

Knife Selection and Maintenance

- Choosing the right knife for the task is crucial for efficiency and safety.
- Different knives serve different purposes, including chef's, paring, serrated, utility, boning, and fillet knives.
- Regular sharpening and honing maintain a safe, effective cutting edge.

Essential Knife Cuts

- Mastering julienne, dice, chiffonade, and other cuts improves precision and consistency.
- Each cut has specific applications and can improve both presentation and cooking performance.

Proper Chopping, Slicing, and Dicing

- Correct hand placement and cutting motions reduce the risk of injury.
- Uniform pieces cook more evenly.

Knife Safety

- Keep knives sharp to reduce slips.
- Use a stable cutting board.
- Never leave knives in the sink or submerged in water.
- Avoid distractions and remain focused while cutting.

Proper Knife Selection and Handling

There are many types of kitchen knives, but these are the most common:

- Chef's Knife: A versatile, multipurpose knife for foods ranging from cheese and vegetables to thick cuts of meat.
- Utility Knife: A smaller chef's knife used for firm or soft vegetables and smaller pieces of meat.
- Paring Knife: A small, pointed knife for peeling and cutting fruit and vegetables or trimming fat.
- Santoku Knife: A Japanese all-purpose knife suited to slicing, dicing, and mincing.
- Boning Knife: Used to separate meat from bone; it can also fillet fish, peel, and trim vegetables.
- Bread Knife: Its serrated blade cuts bread without crushing it and is also useful for some cakes, meat, poultry, and seafood.
- Cleaver: A wide, heavy blade for cutting through bones, meat, and hard vegetables.
- Kitchen Shears: Kitchen scissors for herbs, vegetables, and poultry.
- Steak Knife: A serrated table knife for meat and fish.

The Essential Trio

In a well-equipped kitchen, three knives are truly essential: a versatile chef's knife, a precise paring knife, and a serrated knife. Other knives may add convenience, but they are not necessities.

Nakiri and Santoku Chef's Knives

Nakiri Knife

The Nakiri is designed for quick, efficient vegetable preparation. Its flat blade and squared-off edge suit precise up-and-down chopping and the roll-cut technique.

Chef's Knife

The chef's knife is the workhorse of the kitchen. Its versatility covers tasks ranging from intricate vegetable dicing to larger-scale poultry butchering.

Santoku Knife

The Japanese Santoku has a straight edge that encourages short downward strokes. It is lighter and finer than many Western chef's knives, making it ideal for precise cuts. For cutting through bone, use a heavy Western chef's knife or cleaver.

Boning and Fillet Knives

Boning Knives

Boning knives are made for separating meat from bone and cutting through sinew, muscle, fat, and connective tissue. Their slender blades are sturdy, slightly flexible, and usually made from stainless or high-carbon steel. A pointed tip helps pierce meat.

A boning knife can separate meat from bone, remove skin, cut ligaments and connective tissue, core an apple, or carve a cake.

Fillet Knives

A fillet knife is thinner and more flexible than a boning knife, with a pronounced curve toward its pointed tip. It is suited to filleting fish, removing scales, segmenting citrus, finely mincing onions or shallots, and preparing fruit and vegetables with precision.

The key difference is maneuverability. A fillet knife bends slightly to glide through delicate fish and remove skin. A boning knife is more rigid and suited to tougher work. Using a flexible fillet knife for heavy boning tasks is difficult and may cause the blade to snap.



Safe Knife Handling

The Pinch Grip

Do not grasp only the handle with your cutting hand. Keep your palm close to the base of the blade and pinch the blade where it meets the handle with your thumb and index finger.

The Bear Claw

Curl the fingers of your guiding hand under and press your knuckles against the ingredient. This keeps fingertips away from the blade while holding food securely in place.

Secure the Cutting Surface

Place a rubber mat or a damp paper towel beneath the cutting board to prevent slipping.

Keep Knives Sharp

Use a whetstone or sharpening stone to sharpen the edge and a honing steel to realign it. Hand-wash knives to prevent contact damage and corrosion. Store them in protective sheaths or a knife block.

Basic Cutting Techniques

1. Slice

Move the knife in a rocking, tip-to-heel motion to cut cleanly through food. Move the knife after each cut rather than pushing the food. Experienced cooks use the middle knuckle of the guiding hand as a width guide.

Slicing an Onion

Remove the stem end, place the onion on the cut surface, and halve it through the root. Peel the onion while keeping the root intact so the layers stay together.

2. Bias Slice

Cut elongated items such as carrots, cucumbers, or bananas diagonally. A sharper angle creates broader slices.

3. Mince

Place your free hand flat on the knife tip. Hold the tip down and rock the heel up and down over herbs, ginger, or garlic until finely minced.

Dice, Wedges and Chiffonade

4. Dice

Cut food into even slices, stack two or three slices, and cut them lengthwise into sticks. Hold the sticks together with the claw hand and cut crosswise into uniform dice.

Dicing Onions

1. Halve the onion through the stem, leaving the root intact.
2. Place the cut side down and make even lengthwise cuts without cutting through the root.
3. Hold the onion flat and make two or three horizontal slices.
4. Slice crosswise to release the dice.

5. Wedges

Halve potatoes or onions lengthwise, place the cut sides down, halve again, and cut through the center of each quarter. Keep the root intact while cutting onions, cabbage, or lettuce so the wedges hold together.

6. Chiffonade

Stack four or five dry leaves, roll them into a tight cylinder, and slice crosswise into thin ribbons. Separate and use as a garnish.

Julienne and Brunoise

7. Julienne

Julienne (joo-lee-EN), also called a long cut, produces thin matchstick shapes. It is ideal for vegetables that need even cooking and adds a refined texture to dishes.

8. Brunoise

Brunoise (broo-NWAHZ) is a very fine dice made from julienned food. It is ideal for sauces, soups, and garnishes where small, even pieces add flavor and texture without overpowering the dish.

Module 2 Quiz

1. Which is NOT a common type of kitchen knife?
 - a) Chef's knife
 - b) Butter knife
 - c) Paring knife
 - d) Santoku knife
2. What is the bear-claw technique used for?
 - a) Sharpening the knife
 - b) Holding food safely while cutting
 - c) Grasping the knife handle firmly
 - d) Cleaning the cutting board
3. When slicing, what is recommended?
 - a) Move the food back and forth
 - b) Move your guiding fingers forward after each cut
 - c) Use a sawing motion
 - d) Rock the knife while keeping the food stationary
4. What is the best way to prevent a cutting board from slipping?
 - a) Place a damp paper towel underneath it
 - b) Place it on a smooth countertop
 - c) Secure it with clamps
 - d) Cut on a towel
5. How should knives be stored?
 - a) Loose in a drawer
 - b) In a knife block or protective sheath
 - c) In an uncovered plastic container
 - d) Hanging by the handle

Cooking Methods: Visual Example



Cooking Methods and Techniques

1. Sauteing, Searing, and Pan-Frying

- Sauteing cooks food quickly in a small amount of fat over high heat. It is ideal for vegetables, meat, seafood, and tofu.
- Searing quickly browns the surface of meat over high heat to deepen flavor, often before roasting or braising.
- Pan-frying uses more fat than sauteing, usually reaching about halfway up the food. Examples include schnitzel, fried chicken, and crispy tofu.

2. Roasting, Baking, and Broiling

- Roasting uses high, dry oven heat, usually with the food uncovered. It suits meat, poultry, vegetables, fruit, potatoes, and nuts.
- Baking generally uses lower oven temperatures and is used for cakes, cookies, bread, casseroles, and quiches.
- Broiling cooks food under direct heat from above and is useful for quickly cooking meat, seafood, vegetables, and cheese-topped dishes.

Braising, Steaming and Poaching

3. Braising, Stewing, and Simmering

- Braising slowly cooks food in a small amount of liquid, usually in a covered pot or Dutch oven. It is suited to tougher cuts such as brisket, pork shoulder, and lamb shanks.
- Stewing is similar to braising, but the ingredients are cut into smaller pieces and cooked in more liquid.
- Simmering cooks food gently in liquid just below boiling and is used for soups, stocks, sauces, and poaching liquids.

4. Steaming, Poaching, and Blanching

- Steaming cooks food with steam, helping retain nutrients and flavor.
- Poaching gently cooks delicate foods such as fish, eggs, and fruit in low-temperature liquid.
- Blanching briefly boils food before chilling it in ice water. It partially cooks vegetables before sauteing, stir-frying, freezing, or peeling.

Chef's Tip: Build Flavor with Liquid

Use stock, wine, broth, or aromatics-infused water instead of plain water when poaching.

1. **Infusion of Flavors:** Vegetables, herbs, spices, and meat remnants release flavor into stock. The poached food absorbs those complex aromas as it cooks.
2. **Depth and Complexity:** Long simmering develops and concentrates a flavorful base that plain water cannot provide.
3. **Umami Boost:** Meat, bones, mushrooms, and vegetables contribute glutamates that deepen savoriness.
4. **Balanced Seasoning:** A seasoned poaching liquid flavors food from the inside out.
5. **Complementary Aromatics:** Onions, garlic, herbs, and spices add further layers of aroma and flavor.
6. **Versatility:** Choose a stock or liquid that complements the ingredient and the flavor profile of the dish.

This simple technique can transform a basic poached dish into a more satisfying culinary experience.

Slow-Roasted Tomato Confit

Elevate Your Dishes with Flavor

Tomato confit is made by slow-roasting tomatoes with olive oil, garlic, a hint of sugar, and dried or fresh herbs. The tender tomatoes can be served as a starter, topping, or condiment.

With about five minutes of preparation, any small, ripe tomato can be used. Slow-roasting for approximately one hour intensifies the natural sweetness and allows the flavors to meld.

Confit is a French technique and preservation method that uses low heat, often with fat or sugar. Cherry tomatoes are especially suited to it, producing a sweet, salty, aromatic, and garlicky umami enhancer for many dishes.

Tomato Confit: Ingredients

Tomatoes

- Use ripe cherry, date, plum, or grape tomatoes. Cherry tomatoes are the preferred choice.

Olive Oil

- Extra-virgin olive oil provides the best flavor; regular olive oil can be substituted.

Sugar

- A small amount helps caramelize the tomatoes and balance their natural acidity.

Garlic and Herbs

- Use fresh minced garlic with oregano, thyme, or rosemary.

Salt and Heat

- Season with coarse salt. Add black pepper to taste or a pinch of peperoncini for heat.

Dietary note: This recipe is gluten-free and dairy-free.

Tomato Confit: Method

1. Preheat the oven to 150°C / 300°F / 130°C fan. Choose a baking tray that holds the tomatoes in a single layer without overlap.
2. Rinse the tomatoes. Halve them and arrange cut-side up, or keep them whole if preferred.
3. Combine minced garlic, salt, herbs, a pinch of sugar, and extra-virgin olive oil in a small bowl.
4. Drizzle the dressing over the tomatoes, coating each one evenly.
5. Slow-roast for approximately one hour, until soft and juicy but not mushy.
6. Serve warm or cool as a topping, condiment, starter, or addition to another dish.

Mastering Essential Cooking Techniques

Sauteing

Cook food quickly in a hot pan with a small amount of fat. Rapid browning develops complex flavors and aromas.

Roasting

Roasting usually uses dry oven heat around 200°C / 400°F or higher. Baking often uses lower temperatures, around 160-175°C / 325-350°F. Reduce the stated temperature by about 20°C / 25°F when using a fan or convection oven.

Braising

Slow-cook meat or vegetables at a low temperature for an extended period. This tenderizes tougher cuts and is ideal for stews and braised dishes.

Simmering

Maintain a low, gentle heat for soups, stews, and sauces so flavors can meld and intensify.

Roast Chicken Perfection

Indulge in tender, juicy roast chicken with crisp skin, a classic comfort food. Roasting a whole chicken typically takes about 90 minutes, depending on its size and the oven temperature.

Proper seasoning is essential, but resting is equally important. Let the chicken rest after cooking so its juices redistribute and the meat remains moist and tender.

Chef's tip: Use leftover roast chicken in salads, sandwiches, soups, or pasta dishes.

Making a Pan Sauce: The Art of Deglazing

Pan drippings and browned bits can become a flavorful sauce while roast meat rests. Deglazing is the process of loosening the fond - the caramelized residue on the pan - with liquid.

After sauteing meat, add about one cup of wine, broth, stock, or water to the hot pan and scrape the bottom with a spatula. Use only rich brown fond; blackened bits can make the sauce bitter.

A balanced pan sauce may include broth or wine, aromatics, minced onions or shallots, mustard, herbs, salt, pepper, and unsalted butter.

Three Steps

1. Saute the aromatics.
2. Deglaze the pan and reduce the liquid.
3. Remove from the heat, stir in mustard and herbs, then gradually whisk in cold butter - about three or four cubes per cup of liquid.

Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper.

Poaching, Roasting and Reduction

Poaching

Poaching suits delicate proteins such as prawns, chicken breast, eggs, and fish. Keep the food fully submerged in liquid at approximately 71-82°C / 160-180°F, well below a boil. The liquid should show only occasional small bubbles. A thermometer helps beginners maintain accuracy.

Roasting Vegetables

Avoid overcrowding the pan and preheat the oven fully. Adequate heat and space produce crisp, tender, caramelized vegetables rather than limp, watery results.

Sauce Reduction

Simmer a liquid until some water evaporates. The sauce thickens and its flavor becomes more concentrated. Add salt near the end; salting too early can make the reduced sauce overly salty.

Boiling Eggs and Mastering Rice

Perfect Hard-Boiled Eggs

Place eggs in a saucepan and cover with cold water. Bring to a boil uncovered. Once large bubbles appear, remove the pot from the heat, cover, and let stand for 15 minutes. Transfer the eggs to cold water for another 15 minutes, then tap the narrow end and peel.

Classic Rice Cooking

- Use one cup of rice to two cups of water for a 2:1 ratio.
- Bring to a simmer, add a pinch of salt, lower the heat, cover, and cook undisturbed for 20 minutes.
- Rest the rice for 10 minutes before serving.
- Black or red rice may require 50-60 minutes.
- For fluffier white rice, try one cup of rice to 1 1/2 cups of water.

Flavor Enhancements for Rice

- Replace water with chicken or vegetable stock. Add a smashed garlic clove or onion during cooking and discard before serving.
- Add saffron for fragrance and a vibrant yellow color.
- Cook rice in coconut milk with garlic and cilantro for an Asian-inspired variation.
- Add cumin, cinnamon, and raisins for a Moroccan-inspired dish.

The Knuckle Trick

Place the desired amount of rice in a pot and use the first joint of your index finger as a guide for the water level. Do not lift the lid while the rice cooks.

Cooking Like a Pro

1. **Get Organized:** Read the recipe, gather equipment and ingredients, and complete your measuring and chopping before you begin.
2. **Knife Skills:** Learn a secure grip, practice different cuts, and keep knives sharp.
3. **Flavor Development:** Understand how ingredients work together and experiment with herbs, spices, and seasonings.
4. **Technique Mastery:** Practice sauteing, braising, roasting, and baking.
5. **Temperature Control:** Learn to regulate heat and use a thermometer when necessary.
6. **Plating and Presentation:** Consider color, texture, and arrangement so the dish looks as appealing as it tastes.
7. **Taste as You Go:** Adjust seasoning gradually. Trust your senses, especially when identifying unfamiliar or similar-looking ingredients.
8. **Ingredient Quality:** Fresh, seasonal, high-quality ingredients improve flavor, nutrition, and color.
9. **Learn from the Pros:** Watch demonstrations, read professional cookbooks, and take classes.
10. **Practice:** Experiment, learn from both successes and failures, and keep refining your skills.

Chinese Salt & Pepper Prawns



Crisp prawns finished with chilli, coriander, and spring onion.

Chinese Salt & Pepper Prawns

The first time I tasted this simple but very tasty Chinese dish was at Nam Kee restaurant in Amsterdam. It is one of the lesser-known Chinese dishes, but definitely one to try.

Serves: 6 | Prep time: 15 min | Cooking time: 10 min

Ingredients

- 45 g / 1/3 cup cornflour
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 1 tablespoon freshly cracked black pepper
- 750 g / 1.65 lb raw king prawns, peeled and deveined
- 32 g / 1/4 cup vegetable oil for frying
- 32 g / 1/4 cup fresh coriander leaves, chopped
- 1 red chilli, thinly sliced
- 1 green onion, thinly sliced

Preparation

1. Combine the cornflour, salt, pepper, and half the prawns in a large bowl. Toss to coat and shake off excess flour.
2. Heat the oil in a large non-stick frying pan over high heat, or use a deep fryer. Add the prawns and cook for 3-4 minutes, or until pink.
3. Repeat with the remaining prawns.
4. Transfer to a plate and top with coriander, chilli, and spring onion.

Tip: Serve as a starter or as a main dish with noodles and a light Asian salad.

Burrata, Olive Crumble and Basil Pesto



A fresh starter with basil pesto, tomato, and a crisp olive crumble.

Burrata, Olive Crumble and Basil Pesto

A delicious starter with an unexpected balance of flavors. This has been served as a signature starter at my Chef's Table restaurant in France for many summers.

Serves: 2 | Prep time: 15 min | Cooking time: 20-25 min

Ingredients

- 1 large burrata cheese, sliced in half
- 1 strand cherry tomatoes on the vine, about 8-10 tomatoes
- 100 g Kalamata olives, pitted and finely chopped
- 200 g stale bread, diced
- 1 small bag rocket (arugula) salad
- Basil pesto, homemade or good-quality store-bought
- A pinch of coarse salt
- Freshly ground black pepper
- Balsamic cream or reduction
- Olive oil
- Cherry tomato confit
- Toasted garlic baguette, to serve

Olive Crumble

1. Preheat the oven to 180°C / 350°F / 160°C fan.
2. Pulse the Kalamata olives once or twice in a food processor to create a rough texture.
3. Add the diced bread and pulse again. The mixture should remain coarse, not creamy.
4. Spread on a baking sheet and bake for 20-25 minutes, turning once. Cool completely so it becomes crisp.

Burrata: Assembly and Serving

1. Drain the burrata and carefully slice it in half.
2. Divide the rocket salad between two plates and place a burrata half on each, sliced side down.
3. Add three cherry tomato confit pieces to each plate.
4. Drizzle with good-quality olive oil and balsamic reduction.
5. Season with coarse salt and freshly ground black pepper.
6. Scatter olive crumble over the salad and burrata.
7. Add a spoonful of basil pesto and serve with toasted garlic baguette.

Tip: Dress the rocket with a simple vinaigrette. Store unused olive crumble in an airtight container at room temperature for up to one week.

About burrata: Keep it in its liquid until you are ready to plate. Burrata is highly perishable and usually keeps no longer than three days in the refrigerator.

Vegetable Pad Thai with Fried Tofu



Rice noodles, crisp tofu, lime, bean sprouts, and peanuts.

Vegetable Pad Thai with Fried Tofu

A recipe inspired and adapted from a cookbook discovered during one of my travels to Thailand.

Serves: 4 | Prep time: 20 min | Cooking time: 10 min

Ingredients

- 1 tablespoon neutral oil, such as canola or sunflower oil
- 1 small red pepper, deseeded and thinly sliced
- 400 g firm tofu, cut into 2.5 cm cubes
- 1 garlic clove, minced
- 1 tablespoon fish sauce
- 3 spring onions, thinly sliced, green and white parts
- 4 tablespoons sweet soy sauce
- Juice of 1 lime
- 1 cup bean sprouts
- 1/4 cup chopped peanuts
- 300 g Thai rice noodles
- Lime wedges, to garnish

Sauce

- 1 1/2 tablespoons tamarind puree
- 3 tablespoons packed brown sugar
- 2 tablespoons fish sauce
- 1 1/2 tablespoons oyster sauce

Pad Thai: Method

1. Whisk the sauce ingredients together and set aside.
2. Heat half the oil in a wok over high heat. Fry the tofu on all sides, transfer to a plate, and set aside.
3. Place the noodles in a large bowl and cover with boiling water. Soak for 5-7 minutes, drain, and rinse briefly under cold water to stop the cooking.
4. Return the wok to high heat. Add the remaining oil and stir-fry the pepper for about one minute.
5. Add the garlic, fish sauce, noodles, and soy sauce, stirring constantly.
6. Fold in the bean sprouts, tofu, spring onions, lime juice, and tamarind sauce.
7. Adjust the seasoning, remove from the heat, garnish with chopped peanuts, and serve immediately.

Vegan Dumplings in Creamy Curry Sauce



Golden potato-tofu kofta in a fragrant coconut curry sauce.

Vegan Dumplings: Ingredients

Serves: 6-8 | Prep time: 20 min | Cooking time: 60 min

Kofta

- 4-6 large starchy potatoes
- 453 g / 1 lb firm or extra-firm tofu
- 120 g / 1/2 cup cornstarch or arrowroot starch, plus more if needed
- 2 tablespoons finely chopped fresh cilantro, leaves and stems
- 1 tablespoon freshly squeezed lemon juice
- 2 teaspoons garam masala
- 1 1/2 teaspoons salt
- 240 g / 1 cup frozen green peas
- Canola or sunflower oil, for frying

Creamy Curry Sauce

- 1 large yellow onion, coarsely chopped
- 1 x 900 g / 32 oz can diced tomatoes
- 3/4 cup cashews
- 4 garlic cloves, finely chopped
- 2.5 cm / 1 inch fresh ginger, chopped
- 1 1/2 teaspoons garam masala
- 1 teaspoon ground turmeric
- 1/4 teaspoon cayenne pepper
- 1 teaspoon salt
- 1 x 443 ml / 15 oz can coconut milk
- 1 teaspoon fenugreek seeds, or yellow mustard seeds
- Fresh coriander, to garnish

Vegan Dumplings: Sauce and Kofta

1. Preheat the oven to 220°C / 425°F / 200°C fan if baking the kofta.
2. Peel and halve the potatoes. Cover with water, bring to a boil, and cook for 10-15 minutes until tender. Drain, mash until smooth, and set aside.
3. Combine the onion, tomatoes and juices, cashews, garlic, ginger, garam masala, turmeric, cayenne, salt, and fenugreek or mustard seeds in a heavy-bottomed pot.
4. Cover and simmer over medium heat for 15 minutes, stirring occasionally.
5. Blend the sauce until smooth, venting the blender to release hot air. Return it to the pot and add the coconut milk, reserving 1/4 cup. Cover and set aside.
6. Mash or process the tofu until creamy, with no large chunks.
7. Add the potatoes, cornstarch, cilantro, lemon juice, garam masala, and salt. Form a test ball with one tablespoon of mixture. If it is too wet, add more cornstarch.
8. Fold in the peas and shape equal portions into balls.

Vegan Dumplings: Cooking and Serving

To Fry

Heat about 5 cm / 2 inches of high-heat oil in a heavy-bottomed pot over medium-low heat. Fry the kofta in batches until deep golden brown, turning halfway, for about 5-10 minutes. Drain on paper towels.

To Bake

Line a baking tray with parchment and brush with oil. Arrange the kofta 2-3 cm apart and brush the tops with oil. Bake for 30-40 minutes, turning after 18-20 minutes, until golden on both sides and crisp at the edges.

To Serve

Pour sauce over only the kofta you plan to eat immediately so they do not become soggy. Drizzle with the reserved coconut milk, garnish with coriander, and serve with Indian flatbread or basmati rice.

Chef's note: Yukon Gold potatoes are a good balance of starchy and waxy and are less crumbly than floury potatoes.

Pressure Cooker Turkey Breast

Serves: 8 | Prep time: 10 min | Cooking time: about 55 min

Ingredients

- 1.4 kg boneless turkey breast, thawed
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tablespoons unsalted butter
- 1 tablespoon paprika
- 500 ml chicken stock
- 2 sprigs fresh rosemary
- 2-3 sprigs fresh thyme
- 1 tablespoon olive oil, for rubbing
- 1 tablespoon herbes de Provence or herbs de Bordeaux
- 3 teaspoons salt
- 3 teaspoons freshly ground black pepper
- 2 tablespoons olive oil, for searing

Gravy

- 2 tablespoons unsalted butter
- 2 tablespoons flour
- 120 ml chicken stock
- 125 ml full-fat milk or cream

Pressure Cooker Turkey: Method

1. Rub one tablespoon olive oil over the turkey. Season with paprika, dried herbs, salt, pepper, and minced garlic.
2. Heat the butter and remaining oil in the pressure cooker. Sear the turkey on all sides for 5-7 minutes.
3. Add the chicken stock and bring to a gentle boil.
4. Close the lid and select the correct pressure setting according to the manufacturer's instructions.
5. Bring the cooker to pressure, then cook for 35-55 minutes depending on the size and weight of the breast.
6. Remove the cooker from the heat and release the pressure completely. Carefully unlock and remove the lid.
7. Transfer the turkey to a platter, keep warm, and rest for 10 minutes before slicing.

Gravy

Melt the butter in the cooker. Whisk in the flour and cook for a few minutes. Gradually whisk in the stock and milk or cream. Cook for 3-5 minutes until thickened, then season to taste.

Serve with creamy potato puree, honey-glazed carrots, gravy, and cranberry sauce.

Searing the Perfect Steak

1. Choose the Right Steak: Select a good-quality steak at least 2.5 cm / 1 inch thick, such as ribeye, New York strip, or filet mignon.
2. Bring to Room Temperature: Remove the steak from the refrigerator 30-60 minutes before cooking.
3. Season: Season both sides generously with salt and pepper. Add garlic powder, paprika, or herbs if desired.
4. Preheat the Pan: Heat a heavy-bottomed skillet, preferably cast iron, over high heat.
5. Add Oil: Use a high-smoke-point oil such as canola, vegetable, or grapeseed oil.
6. Sear: Place the steak in the pan and do not move it while the crust forms. Sear each side for 2-4 minutes, depending on thickness and desired doneness.
7. Flip with Tongs: Do not pierce the steak with a fork, which can release juices.
8. Optional Butter Baste: Add butter, a smashed garlic clove, and fresh thyme. Tilt the pan and spoon the foaming butter over the steak.
9. Check Doneness: For medium-rare, aim for 54-57°C / 130-135°F. The steak will continue cooking as it rests.
10. Rest and Slice: Rest for 5-10 minutes, then slice against the grain.

Bavette Steak



Bavette is best served no more than medium for tenderness and flavor.

Bavette Steak

Bavette steak, also known as flap steak or flap meat, is a flavorful cut from the flank area of the cow. It is less expensive than tenderloin or ribeye and can be delicious when cooked properly.

Ingredients

- Bavette steak
- Salt and pepper
- Olive oil
- Optional: garlic, butter, and herbs

Method

1. Remove the steak from the refrigerator about 30 minutes before cooking.
2. Season both sides generously with salt and pepper. Add garlic, herbs, or spices if desired.
3. Preheat a grill or skillet over medium-high heat.
4. Drizzle the steak with olive oil and cook for about 3-4 minutes per side for medium-rare, adjusting for thickness and preferred doneness.
5. Rest for several minutes so the juices redistribute.
6. Slice against the grain and serve.

Bavette is best cooked no more than medium to preserve tenderness and flavor.

Stocks, Sauces, and Soups



Stocks provide depth; thickeners and emulsions shape texture.

Making Flavorful Stocks from Scratch

Stocks are the foundation of many dishes. They are made by gently simmering bones, vegetables, aromatics, and seasonings in water to extract flavor.

- Choose high-quality ingredients, including bones with meat and connective tissue for richness.
- Common aromatics include onions, carrots, celery, herbs, and spices.
- Simmer slowly over low heat. Boiling can make stock cloudy.
- Skim impurities from the surface to clarify the liquid.
- Use homemade stock in soups, stews, sauces, risottos, and braised dishes.

Classic Sauces

- Bechamel: White roux and milk; used for macaroni and cheese, lasagna, and gratins.
- Veloute: Light roux with chicken, fish, or veal stock; used with poultry and seafood.
- Espagnole: Brown roux and brown stock; a base for demi-glace and other rich sauces.
- Hollandaise: Butter, egg yolks, and lemon juice; served with eggs, vegetables, and seafood.

Soup-Making Techniques

Soups range from clear broths to thick, creamy purees. Understanding each style helps you control consistency and flavor.

- Sauté aromatics before adding liquid to build depth.
- Deglaze the pot to capture browned flavor.
- Add broth or stock and simmer ingredients gently.
- Adjust seasoning at the end.
- Explore clear broths, cream-based soups, pureed soups, and chunky soups such as minestrone.

Thickening Agents and Emulsions

Thickening agents give sauces, soups, and other dishes the desired consistency. Common choices include roux, cornstarch, arrowroot, gelatin, and egg yolks.

Advanced Ingredients



Working with Specialty Ingredients

Truffles

Truffles have a strong, earthy flavor. Use them sparingly so they do not overpower other ingredients. Shave them over pasta, risotto, or scrambled eggs.

Foie Gras

Foie gras is rich and buttery and pairs well with sweet or acidic ingredients. Pan-sear and serve with fruit compote or a reduction sauce.

Saffron

Saffron adds a unique flavor and vibrant color. Use it in risotto, paella, or desserts such as saffron-infused ice cream. Infuse the threads in warm liquid before adding them to the dish to extract their full flavor.

Saffron



Bloom saffron threads in warm liquid before adding them to a dish.

Pairing Ingredients for Maximum Impact

1. Contrast: Pair sweet with savory, spicy with mild, or crunchy with creamy. For example, combine spicy chorizo with sweet roasted red pepper.
2. Complement: Choose ingredients that enhance one another, such as grilled salmon with citrus-herb butter.
3. Texture: Combine crisp, creamy, chewy, and crunchy elements for a dynamic eating experience.

Food Synergy and Balance

- Balance sweet, salty, sour, bitter, and umami.
- Use textural contrast to add interest.
- Consider color, shape, and plating technique.

Creating Signature Dishes

- Experiment with new ingredients, techniques, and combinations.
- Add a personal touch that reflects your style, background, or culture.
- Refine recipes through tasting and feedback.

Oven Conversions

Gas	°F	°C	Fan °C
1	275	140	120
2	300	150	130
3	325	170	150
4	350	180	160
5	375	190	170
6	400	200	180
7	425	220	200
8	450	230	210
9	475	240	220

Baking Temperatures and Measures

Metric	Fluid ounces
15 ml	1/2 fl oz
30 ml	1 fl oz
59 ml	2 fl oz
118 ml	4 fl oz
237 ml	8 fl oz
473 ml	16 fl oz
946 ml	32 fl oz
1.9 L	64 fl oz
3.8 L	128 fl oz

Fahrenheit to Celsius: subtract 32, multiply by 5, then divide by 9. Celsius to Fahrenheit: multiply by 9, divide by 5, then add 32. One cup equals 16 tablespoons, 8 fluid ounces, or approximately 240 ml. One tablespoon equals 3 teaspoons, 1/2 fluid ounce, or 15 ml.

Buttermilk Substitute

Make 1 Cup of Buttermilk

Measure one tablespoon fresh lemon juice or white vinegar into a measuring cup. Add whole milk to the one-cup line, stir, and let stand for 5-7 minutes. The milk will thicken and curdle slightly.

Liquid Cup Conversions

- 1/4 cup = 60 ml
- 1/3 cup = 80 ml
- 1/2 cup = 125 ml
- 2/3 cup = 150 ml
- 3/4 cup = 175 ml
- 1 cup = 250 ml
- 1 1/2 cups = 375 ml
- 2 cups = 500 ml
- 4 cups = 1 liter

If You Are Missing an Ingredient

- 1 tsp baking powder: 1/4 tsp baking soda + 1/2 tsp cream of tartar
- 1 cup packed brown sugar: 1 cup granulated sugar + 1/4 cup molasses
- 1 egg: 2 tbsp water + 1/2 tsp baking powder for cookies or cakes; or 1/2 banana or 1/4 cup applesauce for batter breads or brownies
- 1 cup butter: 7/8 cup vegetable oil + 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp lemon juice: 1/2 tsp vinegar
- 1 cup buttermilk: 1 cup plain yogurt
- 1 cup half-and-half: 7/8 cup whole milk + 2 tbsp melted unsalted butter
- 1 cup honey: 3/4 cup sugar + 1/4 cup liquid
- 1 cup corn syrup: 1 cup sugar + 1/4 cup liquid
- 1 tsp cornstarch: 2 tsp flour
- 1 cup cream: 1/3 cup butter + 2/3 cup milk
- 1 oz unsweetened chocolate: 4 tbsp cocoa powder + 1 tbsp butter
- 1 cup sour cream: 1 cup milk + 1 1/3 tbsp vinegar
- 1 cup sugar: 3/4 cup honey + 1/4 cup flour
- 1 cup powdered sugar: 1 cup sugar + 1/3 tsp cornstarch; blend in small batches until powdered
- 1 cup whole milk: 3/4 cup evaporated milk + 1/4 cup water

Cooking Substitutions

A pinch of patience, a dash of kindness, a spoonful of laughter, and a heap of love.

1 Whole Egg

- 3 tbsp water + 1 tbsp chia seeds; rest until gelled
- 3 tbsp water + 1 tbsp ground flax; blend until thick and creamy
- 3 tbsp water + 1 tbsp soy protein powder
- 1 tbsp water + 1 tbsp agar
- 1/2 mashed banana
- 1/4 cup unsweetened applesauce
- 3 tbsp peanut butter

Other Substitutions

- 1 cup heavy cream: 3/4 cup warm milk + 1/3 cup melted butter or margarine
- 1 tsp allspice: 1/2 tsp cinnamon + 1/4 tsp nutmeg + 1/4 tsp ground clove
- 1 minced onion: 1/2 tsp onion powder
- 1 cup buttermilk: 1 tbsp vinegar or lemon juice, then enough milk to make 1 cup; stand 5 minutes
- 1 tsp pumpkin pie spice: 1/2 tsp cinnamon + 1/4 tsp ginger + 1/8 tsp allspice + 1/8 tsp nutmeg
- 1 cup half-and-half: 1 1/2 tbsp butter or margarine + enough milk to make 1 cup
- 1 tbsp mustard: 1/2 tsp dry mustard powder + 2 tsp white vinegar
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning: 1/2 tsp dried basil + 1/4 tsp oregano + 1/4 tsp thyme

Plating Inspiration



Plate Composition and Visual Appeal

1. Balance: Distribute elements evenly and use the rule of thirds to position key components.
2. Negative Space: Leave open areas so the dish stands out. Avoid overcrowding the plate.
3. Color Contrast: Combine vibrant ingredients with neutral tones for a striking presentation.

Garnishing Techniques



Fresh herbs and microgreens add height, freshness, and color.

Garnishing Techniques

1. Herbs and Microgreens: Add parsley, cilantro, or microgreens strategically on top of the main components.
2. Edible Flowers: Use pansies, nasturtiums, and other edible flowers as delicate garnishes.
3. Sauces and Drizzles: Practice dots, sweeps, and controlled drizzles to create artistic patterns without overwhelming the plate.

Color, Texture and Height



Contrast, texture, and height create visual interest and dimension.

Color, Texture and Height

1. Color: Use colorful ingredients and contrasting tones to create a vibrant presentation.
2. Texture: Combine crispy, creamy, crunchy, and velvety components to add interest and depth.
3. Height: Stack or layer components and use rolled vegetables or vertical elements to build dimension.

Food Styling for Photography



A clear focal point, soft light, and restrained props keep attention on the food.

Food Styling Tips for Photography

1. Natural Lighting: Use soft window light. Diffuse harsh light with a sheer curtain.
2. Background: Choose a clean, simple background that does not compete with the dish. Use texture and props sparingly.
3. Composition: Apply the rule of thirds and place the main subject slightly off-center.
4. Props and Accessories: Choose utensils, napkins, and fresh ingredients that support the story without overpowering the food.

Course Conclusion

By mastering these plating and presentation techniques, you can elevate your dishes visually and create memorable dining experiences for your guests, as well as stronger images for your culinary portfolio.

By the end of this course, you will have the skills and confidence to tackle more complex recipes, experiment with new ingredients, and impress family and friends with your culinary creations.

Cook better. Every day.

Continue your culinary journey

Practice the techniques, trust your senses, and keep refining the details that turn good cooking into confident cooking.

EPICUREAN FLOW